

cially if technologically savvy, armed with constituency profiles and satellite jammers, seen as the manipulators. Kapoor's observant student, part Arjuna and part Michael Corleone, is just that, doomed to his destiny, selling his brother to the highest bidder to finance the campaign, killing an old faithful to pin the blame on another, and murdering a rival to clear the path of power for his family—no, Rahul Gandhi he is not, nor is he Sanjay Gandhi. Kapoor's Samar doesn't want power for himself. But he does want it all the same, and not because he is moved by the plight of the poor or the hunger of the starving.

It's a sophisticated and complex anti-hero, who is distracted by nothing, not Kaif's Donald Duck lips which whisper sweet nothings into his ear, not his American girlfriend's niggling doubts. There is little difference between him, the ruthless head of a family business or even a Mumbai ganglord. Of course, that is why he's given a cigarette to smoke in his quieter moments, a chess game on his BlackBerry he is addicted to, as well as reading glasses that give

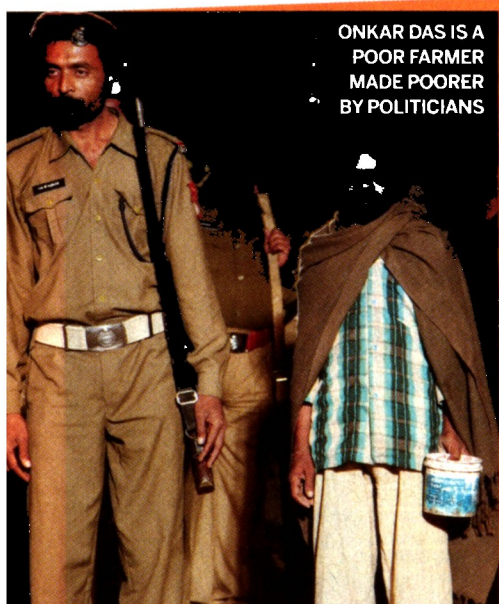


ONCE UPON A TIME IN MUMBAI

"If our cabinet enters politics, Mr Minister, all of you will be sold like junk."

Ajay Devgn, a Haji Mastan-like smuggler, to a minister

DEVGN WITH
KANGANA
RANAUT,
WHO PLAYS A
70s ACTOR



ONKAR DAS IS A
POOR FARMER
MADE POORER
BY POLITICIANS

PEEPLI LIVE

"In politics, we don't have enmity, only differences of opinion."

Naseeruddin Shah, playing a union minister, on a TV news show

him the air of a mobster in mufti. Indeed, Milan Luthria hints at this transformation of the smuggler into a problem-solving politician-in-waiting in the forthcoming *Once Upon a Time in Mumbai*, set in the 1970s. "Towards the end of the Emergency, the seeds were sown of this marriage of the mob and politics, when ordinary people, failed by the government, the police and the judiciary, would approach a Haji Mastan or a Karim Lala to resolve property disputes or family issues. This was the era when the Devdas instead of turning the other cheek would slap right back," says Luthria.

Indeed, India 2010 is vastly different from that early disenchantment with politics. Now the disgust is deep-rooted, down to the village where the schemes named after prime ministers, past and present, converge, providing handpumps where there is no water, jobs where there is no work and homes where there is no money for bribes to get the oh-so-vital BPL certificates. It's the kind of village Natha (Onkar Das) inhabits in Anusha Rizvi's forthcoming *Peepli Live*, where he will be forced to fake his own suicide so his family can get compensation. And politicians can go

on air silkily proclaiming that their *aam aadmi* schemes are uncommon successes. It's the same philosophy that guided the supposedly simple driver in Shyam Benegal's *Well Done Abba* to file an FIR against a well that was craftily constructed only on paper, one of the many ways a Centrally sponsored scheme ends up sponsoring nothing but corruption.

It takes a revolutionary to point out the obvious to the twisted politician in *Raajneeti*, when Naseeruddin Shah's Bhaskar Sanyal says angrily to the chief minister: "Go. We liberate you from your responsibility of removing poverty." Or when Devgn's Sooraj Kumar says: "We are our own owners. We run their kitchens, they don't run ours." In Jha's merciless world of winner-takes-nothing, no one inherits the future. Not the wannabe woman MLA who will sleep her way to a ticket, not the girl in the Lexus convertible who gets her dream of driving in a car with a *lal batti* but only after becoming a widow (Kaif's Hindi accent is worse than Sonia Gandhi's), and certainly not the chief minister's son who wanted a civilised life as a teaching assistant in America. It's a bleak world, agrees *Raajneeti* writer Anjum Rajabali. "But then so is politics today." ■